Alaska Picks Its Youngest Governor Ever

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Alaska has a new **governor**: **Democrat** Jonathan Kreiss-Tomkins, 37, the youngest **governor** in Alaska's history.

Kreiss-Tomkins used to be a state **representative** from Sitka, a small island town. People call him JKT. He wants to work with **Democrats**, Republicans, and **independents**, and called himself a "man of the middle" at a debate.

Many leaders backed him: three former **governors**, a **Democrat**, a Republican, and an **independent**, plus Senator Lisa Murkowski. "I strongly believe people just want things to work, and want people to work together," he said.

It took more than a week to count the votes, including mail votes and votes from far-away parts of the state. Alaska uses **ranked-choice voting**, where voters rank candidates in order. Kreiss-Tomkins beat three Republicans, and a winner needs more than half the votes.

Voters also voted on whether to end **ranked-choice voting**. That idea failed, so the system will stay.

Kreiss-Tomkins starts work at noon on December 7. He will lead a state where many people say things are not working well, costs are rising, and schools have closed.

Word Treasure

governor -- The person who leads a state.
ranked-choice voting -- A way of voting where you list candidates in order.
representative -- A person chosen by voters to speak for them in government.
independent -- A person who does not belong to a political party.
Democrat -- A member of the Democratic Party.

Background you need

A governor is the leader of a state, like a mayor is the leader of a city.

Alaska is the biggest state in the United States.

In an election, voters choose who will lead them, and the winner takes office on a set date.

Break it down

WHO: Jonathan Kreiss-Tomkins, Alaska's new governor
WHAT: The election of a new governor for Alaska
WHERE: In Alaska
WHY: Voters chose him in the election, and he wants to work with people from all parties

Why it matters

The governor makes choices about your schools, roads, and towns, so who wins an election can change life for kids in that state.

Test what you remember

1. Who is Alaska's new governor?

- (A) Jonathan Kreiss-Tomkins
- (B) Donald Trump
- (C) Lisa Murkowski
- (D) Mike Dunleavy

2. How old is he?

- (A) 57
- (B) 47
- (C) 27
- (D) 37

3. What town is he from?

- (A) Juneau
- (B) Sitka
- (C) Fairbanks
- (D) Anchorage

4. How does ranked-choice voting work?

- (A) Voters rank candidates in order
- (B) Voters vote only once
- (C) The president picks the winner
- (D) The oldest candidate wins

5. What did voters also decide?

- (A) Whether to build a new school
- (B) Whether to change the flag
- (C) Whether to end ranked-choice voting
- (D) Whether to move the capital

6. When does he start work?

- (A) In January 2023
- (B) At noon on December 7
- (C) On Election Day
- (D) Next summer

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Jonathan Kreiss-Tomkins: He said people just want things to work, and want people to work together.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):